

The Price of Constraint: Associations Between Regulation, Density, GDP and U.S. Home Prices

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August 2026

Abstract

This paper examines factors associated with housing affordability across 60 U.S. cities. I analyzed the relationships between home prices and variables including regulatory stringency, population density, and GDP, using data from the U.S. Census Bureau, Zillow, and the U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development. Using RStudio, I conducted linear regression analyses and tested the statistical significance of these relationships. My strongest finding was the relationship between regulatory stringency and home prices: over 50% of the variance in metropolitan home prices across my 60 city sample was explained by their linear relationship with regulatory stringency. The paper considers how these findings may inform future approaches to housing affordability.

Introduction

Historically, homeownership has served as the primary means for wealth building in the United States. Oftentimes, people buy a home at an early stage in their life and hope to sell it at a higher value later on, utilizing the home as an investment. However, over recent decades, escalating purchase prices have outpaced middle-class budgets and wage growth, pricing middle-class households out of the buying market. This is ultimately preventing these households from building wealth from real estate while also driving a trend towards long-term renting. This structural shift is driven by a combination of supply constraints and demand-side economic pressures. Housing supply is increasingly being constrained by new laws that limit building heights and areas in which homes can be constructed. With this, it takes a long time to build new homes because of the large number of building codes and regulatory requirements that governments instill. As supply remains inelastic, demand continues to increase as cities become more dense and more economically productive.

As a result, this paper will discuss how local economic factors and housing supply restrictions relate to rising home prices and housing affordability in the United States. The three macroeconomic factors examined are housing supply restrictions, as measured by a city's regulatory stringency index; high population density, which concentrates buyer demand; and strong local economic output, measured by a city's Gross Domestic Product.

Beyond financial implications, the growing barrier to homeownership carries significant psychological and socioeconomic effects because homeownership remains deeply connected to societal milestones of adulthood and financial stability. Recognizing this widespread problem, municipal governments are facing growing pressure to enact new policies that restore housing

access and affordability. However, they often fall short because they fail to address the housing supply shortage felt across many metropolitan areas.

Housing affordability continues to worsen over time as stagnant wages leave families struggling to cover basic living expenses while simultaneously trying to accumulate funds for a down payment. Specifically, in 2024, 45.5% of US households did not earn enough to cover basic necessities such as housing, food, child care, and utilities (Stephens). This strongly affects a family's ability to afford a home, forcing them to rent. The widening affordability gap is also driven by a deficient housing supply. In inelastic urban housing markets, residential construction cannot expand quickly enough to meet ongoing population and economic growth. As a result, there is elevated competition for limited housing inventory, which bids up property values and continues to push homeownership further out of reach.

Municipal governments have attempted to combat the housing supply shortage through various policies, yet many have proven counterproductive. For example, many cities have proposed expanding buyer purchasing power through demand-side interventions. This includes down-payment assistance programs, interest rate buydowns, and penalty-free retirement account withdrawals. While these interventions attempt to boost buyer purchasing power, housing supply still remains static, so purchase prices are even higher as people are willing to pay more to outbid a greater amount of competition. Conversely, direct supply-side policies like repurposing federal land for multi-family zoning are also ineffective. This is because they take a long time to affect housing supply while also facing community opposition, known as NIMBYism, showing that structural reforms rarely provide immediate price relief (Gyourko).

The affordability crisis impacts different demographic groups unequally as well. In fact, high housing costs disproportionately affect communities of color. According to the Brookings Institution, 55% of households of color could not afford basic home necessities in 2024 and non-white households lagged behind state baseline affordability metrics nationwide. This is due to the fact that Black and Latino workers earn just 78 cents for every dollar earned by white workers (Gyourko). This disparity severely affects barriers into housing, restricting households of color from building wealth through real estate.

In addition to demographics, market strain is a geographical pattern that does not follow traditional regional divides. For example, families in Hawaii, West Virginia, and Oregon have the smallest percentages of households that earn enough to make ends meet. On the other hand, families in North Dakota, New Hampshire, and Washington DC have the largest percentages of households that can make ends meet. This suggests that the affordability crisis is not concentrated in certain regions, but is spread all across the United States. The mix of largely differing states on both sides of the affordability spectrum contributes to the idea that rising home prices emerge from a variety of different factors. These factors are split into two categories: the microeconomic factors taken into account in the *New York Times* Rent vs. Buy Calculator and the macroeconomic factors that directly correlate with rising home prices such as Household Income, Stringency, Population Density, Homelessness Rate, and Gross Domestic Product.

Theory and Hypotheses

This section will discuss my theories and hypotheses on the major driving factors of rising home prices and housing affordability. I will then go through a Linear Regression t-Test for each hypothesis to analyze the statistical significance of each variable and the strength of its correlation with home prices. To test these relationships, data was gathered across sixty United States cities. For each city, the microeconomic and macroeconomic factors stated earlier were noted. Statistical analysis was conducted in R Studio.

My hypotheses are that the three strongest factors driving rising home prices are high regulatory stringency, high population density, and high Gross Domestic Product in the cities.

➤ *Primary Hypothesis*

The primary hypothesis is that higher regulatory stringency is significantly associated with higher home prices. The causal mechanism behind this is that cities with high regulatory stringency impose tighter constraints on housing development and limit the land that can be used for construction. As a result, housing supply is limited and unable to keep up with demand from the growing population of the city. With more competition for housing, prices grow and exceed local wages which contribute to elevated rates of homelessness.

After conducting statistical analysis in R Studio, it was first revealed that a city's stringency index exhibited the strongest positive correlation with median home prices among all tested variables (Figure 1).

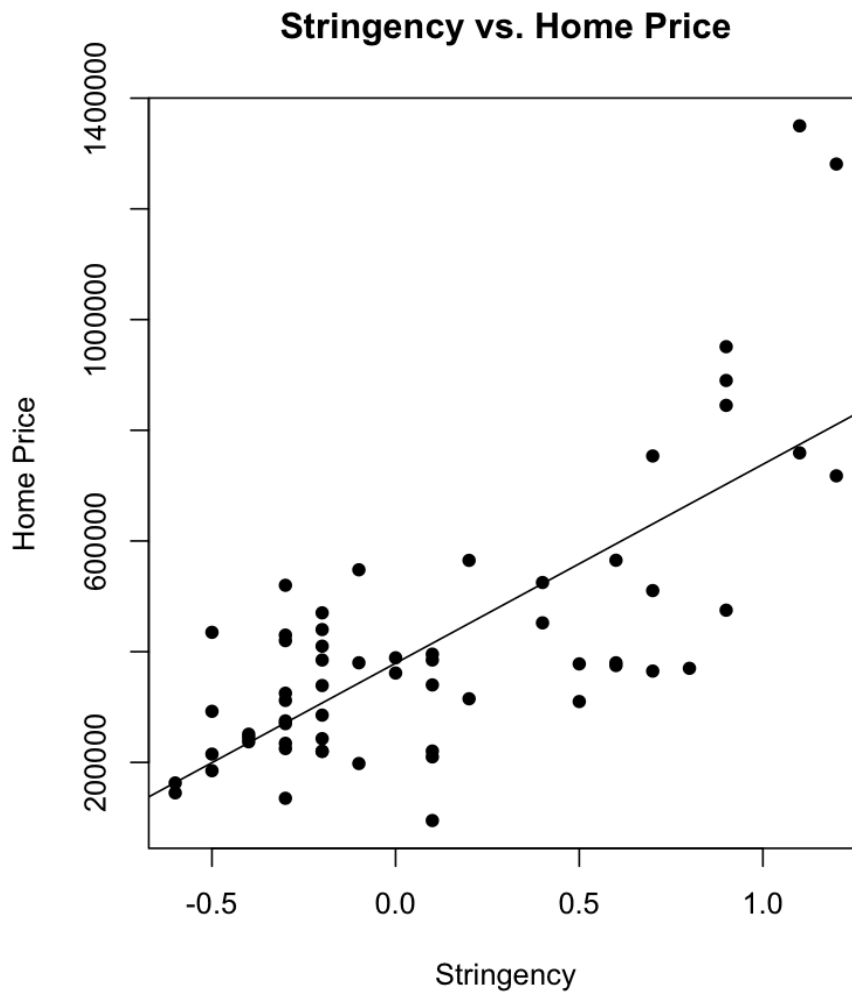


Figure 1

To quantify this relationship, a linear regression was conducted using the Stringency Index as the predictor of Median Home Price. The regression model proved statistically significant ($p < 0.001$), yielding a coefficient of determination of 0.5441, indicating that approximately 54.41% of the variance in metropolitan home prices across the sixty-city sample can be explained by the linear relationship with regulatory stringency. The estimated slope coefficient is around 359,404, meaning that stringency has a positive correlation with home

prices. Specifically, for every one-unit increase in a city's stringency index, median home prices are approximately \$359,404 higher, on average, in the fitted model, starting from an intercept of \$379,252 (Figure 2).

```
Call:
lm(formula = Home_Price ~ Stringency, data = rent_datanew)

Residuals:
    Min       1Q   Median       3Q      Max
-320193  -88738   -7991    95219   575403

Coefficients:
              Estimate Std. Error t value Pr(>|t|)
(Intercept)   379252      22431   16.91  < 2e-16 ***
Stringency    359404      43196    8.32 1.78e-11 ***
---
Signif. codes:
0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1

Residual standard error: 170300 on 58 degrees of freedom
Multiple R-squared:  0.5441,    Adjusted R-squared:  0.5363
F-statistic: 69.23 on 1 and 58 DF,  p-value: 1.783e-11
```

Figure 2

To formally evaluate the first hypothesis that land-use restrictions significantly drive median home prices upward, a Linear Regression T-Test was conducted using the sixty-city dataset. The null and alternate hypotheses are stated below:

$H_0: \beta = 0$ (There is no linear relationship between regulatory stringency and median home prices)

$H_a: \beta > 0$ (There is a positive linear relationship)

Prior to testing statistical significance, core assumptions were evaluated. The residual plot is shown in Figure 3.

1. **Linear:** The scatterplot of Stringency Index versus Median Home Price (Figure 1) demonstrates a clear positive linear trend. The residual plot shows a random scatter with no distinct shape (Figure 3).
2. **Independent:** The sample size of 60 US cities represents less than 10% of all cities in the United States ($60 < 0.10N$). Each observation represents a distinct metropolitan area.
3. **Normal:** Most residual points cluster near the $y = 0$ line. The overall distribution of residuals remains reasonably symmetric with only a few outliers such as points 19 (San Francisco), 40 (Detroit), and 50 (San Jose) (Figure 3).
4. **Equal Variance:** The vertical spread of residuals remains relatively uniform up until much higher fitted values due to extreme outliers (Figure 3).
5. **Random:** The dataset comprises 60 geographically diverse US metropolitan areas. However, the sixty areas were not selected through random sampling. Therefore, the results should be interpreted within the sample, and generalizability to all U.S. metropolitan areas is limited.

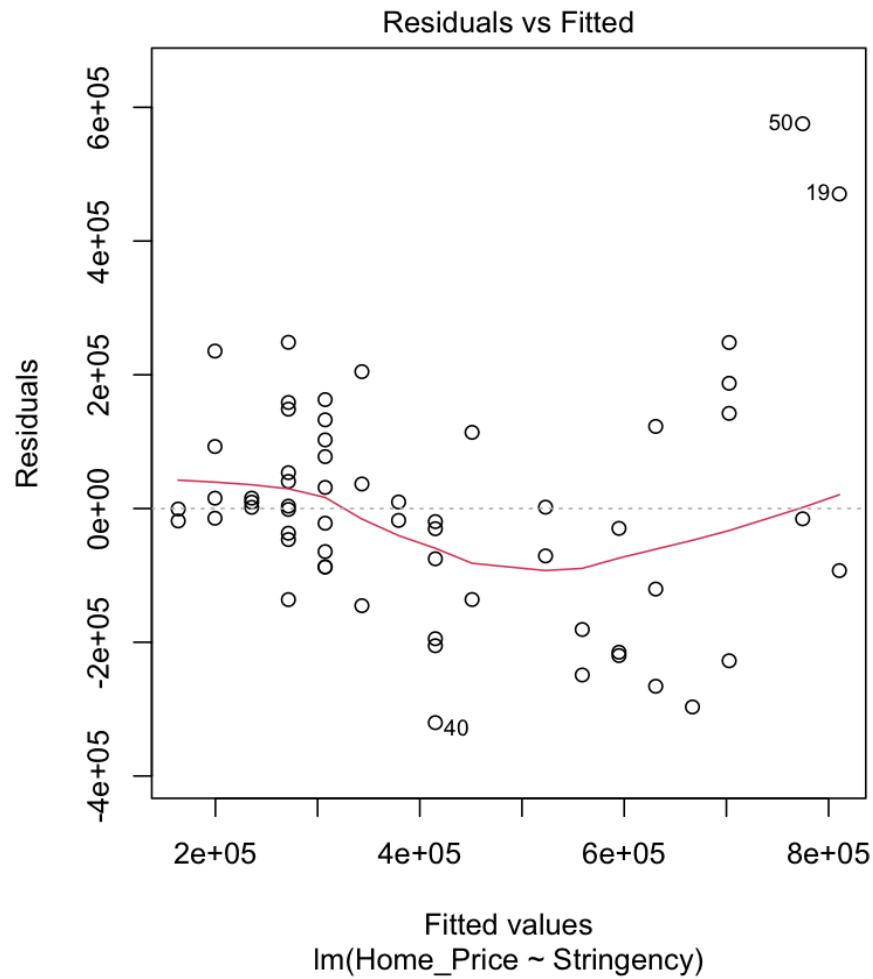


Figure 3

Because the p-value (1.78×10^{-11}) is substantially lower than the significance level ($\alpha = 0.05$), we must reject the null hypothesis. As a result, there is convincing statistical evidence of a positive linear relationship between regulatory stringency and median home prices across US cities.

This finding carries significant real-world economic implications. The R^2 value of 0.5441 demonstrates the substantial role that local regulatory policies may play in housing price variation across U.S. cities. Furthermore, the estimated slope of \$359,404 reveals that even minor increases in zoning strictness are associated with substantial differences in home prices, potentially creating significant financial burdens for homeowners. Therefore, the model suggests that moving from a low-stringency city to a high-stringency city can correspond with differences in home prices of several hundred thousand dollars.

These findings directly explain why certain middle-class buyers and lower-income demographics are increasingly priced out of homeownership. Restrictive zoning practices serve as barriers to development, limiting new housing construction even as urban populations grow. In an inelastic market where demand far outpaces supply, home purchase prices inflate rapidly, pricing middle-income households out of the buyer market entirely (Machin). This dynamic triggers a process known as reverse filtering, where many buyers are forced to remain in the rental market, increasing competition for long-term renting. Landlords respond by raising rents, which allows higher-earning households to outbid middle and lower income households for apartments (Yudhishtu). This forces middle-income renters into lower-cost housing stock, squeezing out low-wage earners who have no cheaper options available. At the bottom of the income spectrum, low-wage households then face severe rent burdens that outpace their total income. These households face budget constraints, eviction, and eventually urban homelessness. This association is shown below (Figure 4).

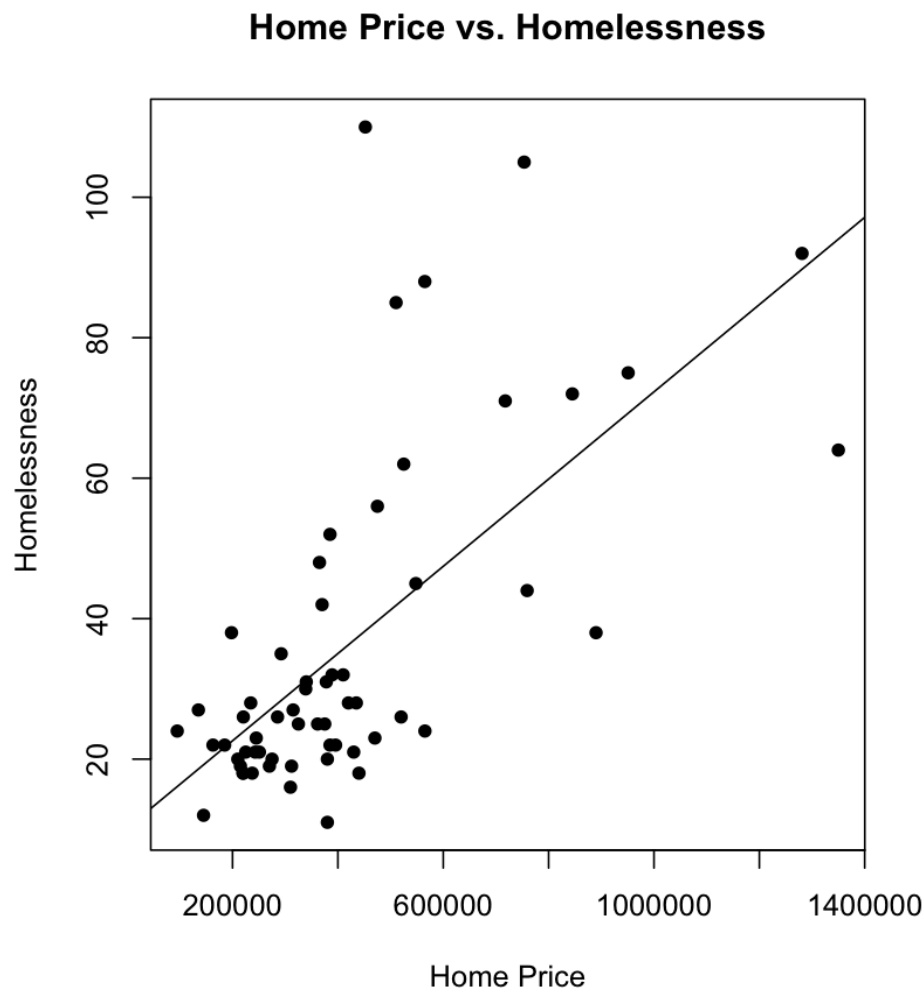


Figure 4

➤ ***Secondary Hypothesis***

The secondary hypothesis is that higher population density is significantly associated with higher home prices. The causal mechanism behind this is that cities with high population densities have more demand for housing in limited land areas. As a result, only higher-income earning families are willing to pay more for the limited housing, which pushes home prices

upward. The prices then become too large for the average family to afford, making them increasingly motivated to rent rather than buy. Furthermore, because dense urban centers face limits on new construction, affordable inventory is limited, which further elevates urban homelessness rates.

Statistical analysis showed that a city's population density had a relatively strong positive correlation with median home prices, but not as strong as a city's stringency index (Figure 5).

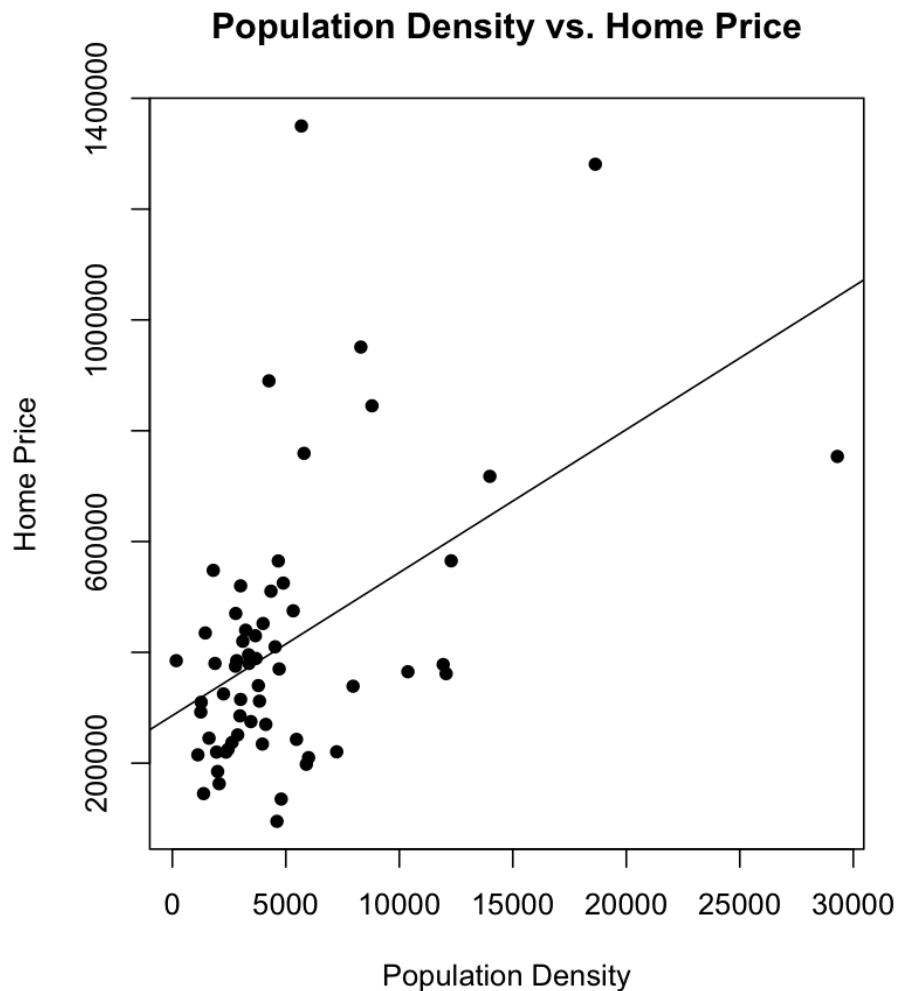


Figure 5

A linear regression was also conducted to quantify the relationship between Population Density in people per square mile and Median Home Price across the sixty-city sample. The model proved statistically significant ($p < 0.001$), yielding a coefficient of determination of 0.237, revealing that approximately 23.7% of the variance in home prices across the sample is explained by population density. The estimated slope coefficient is about 25.81, meaning that for every one-unit increase in population density (people per square mile), median home prices are approximately \$25.81 higher, on average, in the fitted model, starting from an intercept of \$285,900 (Figure 6).

```
Call:
lm(formula = Home_Price ~ PopDensity, data = rent_datanew)

Residuals:
    Min       1Q   Median       3Q      Max
-309827 -133269  -31638   70749  917347

Coefficients:
              Estimate Std. Error t value Pr(>|t|)
(Intercept)  2.859e+05  4.188e+04   6.827 5.73e-09 ***
PopDensity    2.581e+01  6.081e+00   4.245 8.00e-05 ***
---
Signif. codes:
0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1

Residual standard error: 220300 on 58 degrees of freedom
Multiple R-squared:  0.237,    Adjusted R-squared:  0.2239
F-statistic: 18.02 on 1 and 58 DF,  p-value: 7.999e-05
```

Figure 6

To formally evaluate whether population density significantly impacts median home prices, another Linear Regression T-Test was conducted. Below are the null and alternate hypotheses for this test:

$H_0: \beta = 0$ **(There is no linear relationship between population density and median home prices)**

$H_a: \beta > 0$ **(There is a positive linear relationship between population density and median home prices)**

Prior to testing statistical significance, core linear regression assumptions were verified. The residual plot is shown in Figure 7.

1. **Linear:** The scatterplot of Population Density versus Median Home Price (Figure 5) demonstrates a positive linear trend. Although the red trendline in the residual plot slants downward at higher fitted values, the overall scatter lacks a distinct pattern, confirming that a linear model is acceptable (Figure 7).
2. **Independent:** The sample size of 60 US cities represents less than 10% of all cities in the United States ($60 < 0.10N$).
3. **Normal:** Most of the residual points cluster near the $y = 0$ line. High-value outliers like points 19 (San Francisco), 33 (San Diego), and 50 (San Jose) introduce some positive skewness; however, the central distribution is symmetrical towards lower fitted values (Figure 7).
4. **Equal Variance:** The vertical spread of residuals remains relatively uniform at lower fitted values but broadens significantly at higher fitted values, indicating that extreme high-cost outliers have prices that exceed linear regression predictions (Figure 7).

5. **Random:** The dataset comprises 60 geographically diverse US metropolitan areas.

However, the sixty areas were not selected through random sampling. Therefore, the results should be interpreted within the sample, and generalizability to all U.S. metropolitan areas is limited.

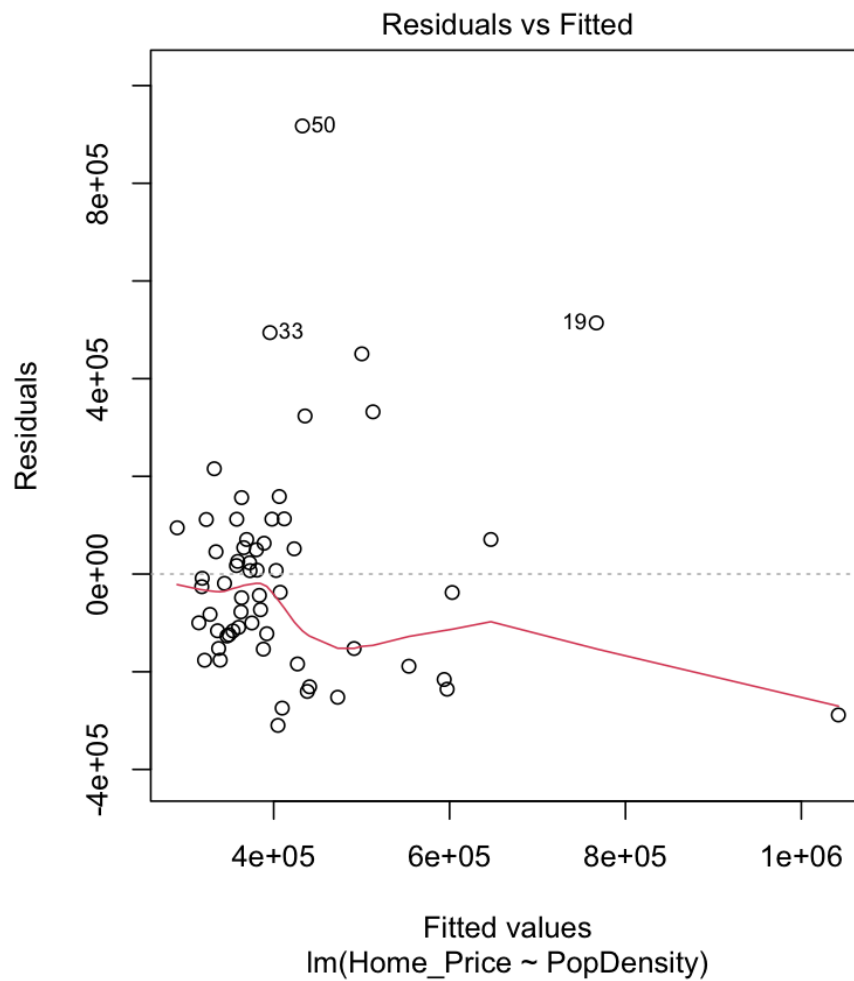


Figure 7

Because the p-value (8.00×10^{-5}) is substantially lower than the significance level ($\alpha = 0.05$), we must reject the null hypothesis. Consequently, there is convincing statistical evidence of a positive linear relationship between urban population density and median home prices across US cities.

This statistical finding demonstrates a significant relationship between population density and urban real estate costs. While regulatory stringency (Hypothesis 1) controls the lack of elasticity for housing supply, population density reflects the large concentration of buyer demand within the fixed supply. An R^2 value of 0.237 demonstrates that population density accounts for about a quarter of the variation in metropolitan home prices across the sample, with each additional person per square mile adding about \$25.81 to median home purchase costs.

This provides a large barrier for families looking to buy a home, shifting them into long-term renting. However, because densely populated cities face physical space constraints, the massive amount of forced renters makes rental prices rise as well. This places large financial strain on low-income earners, establishing a connection between population density and elevated homelessness rates.

➤ *Tertiary Hypothesis*

The third hypothesis posits that cities with larger Gross Domestic Product (GDP) have higher median home prices. The causal mechanism behind this is that cities with larger GDPs have more valuable goods and services. As a result, the cities attract greater business investment and labor. This increases the competition for real estate which further drives up home prices, forcing many families to rent.

Statistical analysis of this relationship revealed that a city's GDP has a relatively strong positive correlation with median home prices, but not as strong as a city's stringency index or population density (Figure 8).

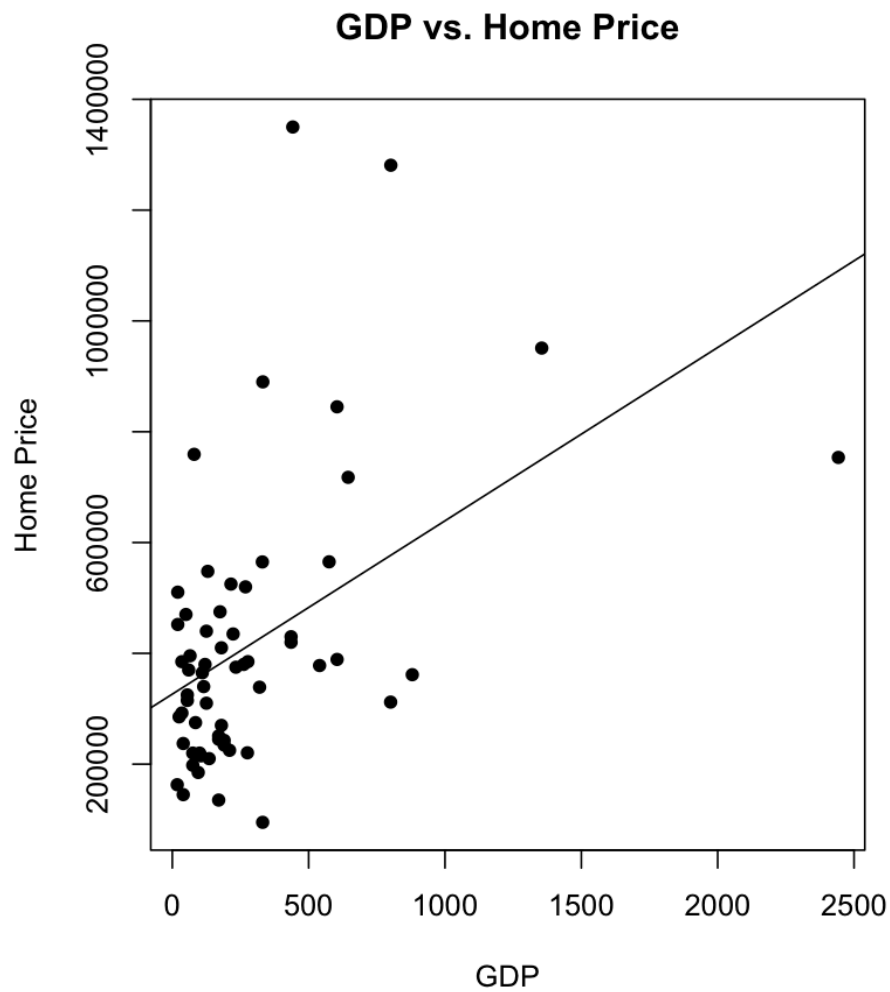


Figure 8

To quantify this relationship, a linear regression was conducted using metropolitan GDP as the predictor of Median Home Prices. The regression model proved statistically significant ($p < 0.001$) with a coefficient of determination of $R^2 = 0.2281$, indicating that approximately 22.81% of the variance in home prices across the sample can be explained by local economic output. The estimated slope coefficient is approximately 312.87, showing that for every \$1 billion increase in metropolitan GDP, median home prices are approximately \$312.87 higher, on average, in the fitted model, starting from an intercept of \$326,415.47 (Figure 9).

```
Call:
lm(formula = Home_Price ~ GDP, data = rent_datanew)

Residuals:
    Min       1Q   Median       3Q      Max
-336993 -139004  -30646   79315  885360

Coefficients:
              Estimate Std. Error t value Pr(>|t|)
(Intercept) 326415.47   35923.79   9.086 9.56e-13 ***
GDP           312.87     75.57   4.140 0.000114 ***
---
Signif. codes:  0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1

Residual standard error: 221600 on 58 degrees of freedom
Multiple R-squared:  0.2281,    Adjusted R-squared:  0.2148
F-statistic: 17.14 on 1 and 58 DF,  p-value: 0.0001139
```

Figure 9

Next, to evaluate whether local GDP has a significant positive linear relationship with median home prices, a Linear Regression T-Test was conducted with the following null and alternate hypotheses:

$H_0: \beta = 0$ **(There is no linear relationship between a city's GDP and median home prices)**

$H_a: \beta > 0$ **(There is a positive linear relationship between a city's GDP and median home prices)**

The following core linear regression assumptions were evaluated using the residual plot shown in Figure 10.

1. **Linear:** The scatterplot of GDP versus Median Home Price (Figure 8) displays a positive linear trend. While the red trendline in the residual plot slants downward at high fitted values, the overall distribution lacks a distinct pattern, confirming that a linear model is acceptable (Figure 10).
2. **Independent:** The sample size of 60 US cities represents less than 10% of all cities in the United States ($60 < 0.10N$).
3. **Normal:** A large majority of the residual points cluster near the $y = 0$ line. High-value outliers like points 19 (San Francisco), 33 (San Diego), and 50 (San Jose) introduce some positive skewness. The distribution remains symmetrical towards lower fitted values, however (Figure 10).
4. **Equal Variance:** The vertical spread of residuals remains relatively uniform at lower fitted values but broadens significantly at higher fitted values. This indicates that extreme high-cost outliers have prices that exceed linear regression predictions of GDP (Figure 10).

5. **Random:** The dataset comprises 60 geographically diverse US metropolitan areas.

However, the sixty areas were not selected through random sampling. Therefore, the results should be interpreted within the sample, and generalizability to all U.S. metropolitan areas is limited.

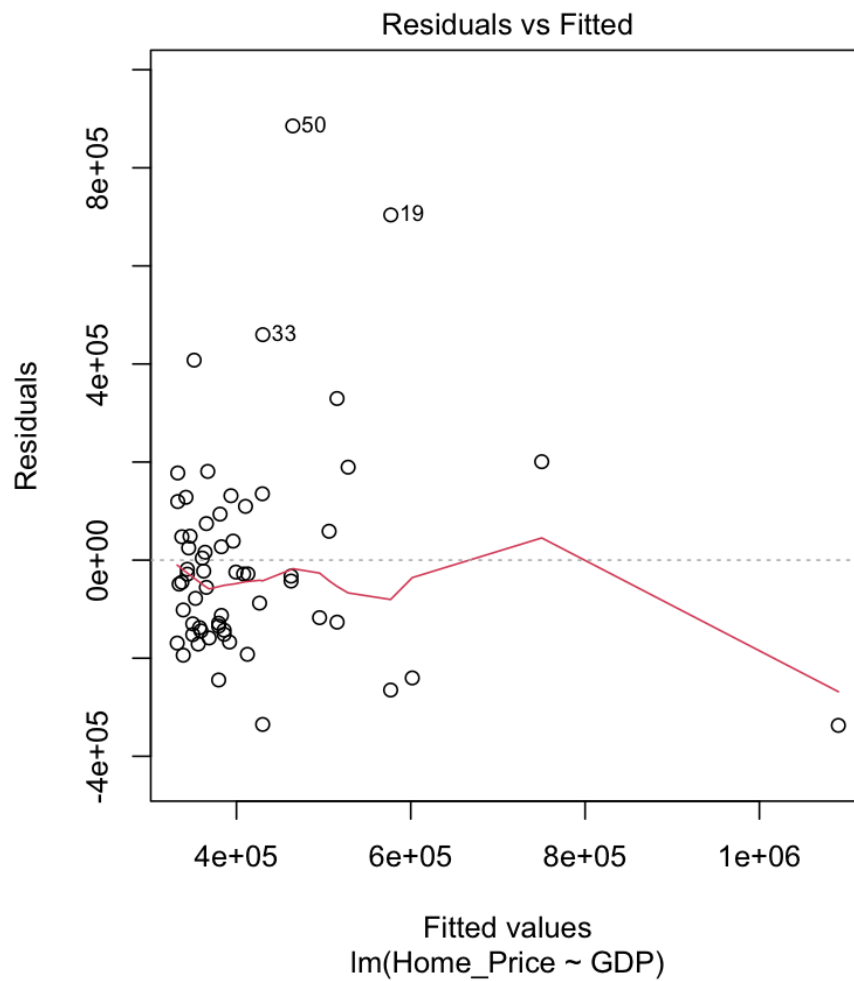


Figure 10

Because the p-value (0.0001139) is substantially lower than the significance level ($\alpha = 0.05$), we must reject the null hypothesis. So, there is convincing statistical evidence of a positive linear relationship between GDP and median home prices across US cities.

These findings demonstrate that strong local economic growth is associated with rising home prices. This is because household incomes and purchasing power are tied to economic productivity. In booming economies, rising GDP attracts more corporate investment and high-wage labor, which expands the pool of buyers that have more purchasing power. As a result, the high-earning households are willing to pay more in the housing market, driving up home prices. However, as the housing costs adjust to align with high local GDP, middle to low income workers are priced out of the purchase market, driving them into renting (“Link Between Economic Growth”).

Policy Recommendation

To combat all of these factors contributing to the rise of home prices which are pricing people out of homeownership, it is important for federal and municipal governments to enact new policies. These governments should keep in mind the three factors examined in this study, which are regulatory stringency, population density, and Gross Domestic Product. The goal of these policies should be to loosen housing regulation so that homes can be built more quickly and in more areas while keeping up with rising populations and economic development.

One factor significantly associated with high home prices in this study is a city’s regulatory stringency ($p = 1.78 \times 10^{-11}$). While this analysis does not establish the causal mechanism behind this relationship, prior research suggests that restrictive zoning creates large barriers to housing construction, limiting the supply of housing in an area. With a rising demand

and an inelastic housing supply, property values are driven upward, leaving renting as the only alternative for lower-income earners (Machin). In fact, regulatory costs, like complying with building codes, zoning, and permits, make up nearly 25% of the cost of building a single family home and about 40% of the cost of the average apartment (National Association of Home Builders).

In order to combat the restricting zoning laws, governments should conduct further research on excessive regulations and make the regulatory process simpler. First of all, the minimum energy standard, which encourages builders to conform to the 2021 International Energy Conservation Code, makes it much harder for home builders to build housing that is affordable for the average American. Rather than eliminating this standard entirely, policymakers should conduct rigorous cost-benefit analyses on local building codes to balance long-term sustainability goals with immediate upfront construction costs (National Association of Home Builders). While energy efficiency reduces utility expenses over time and is overall better for the environment, aggressive building mandates add substantial initial costs that negatively affect entry-level housing. Furthermore, cities should work to reduce the delays between project submission and permit approval. This will minimize holding costs, loan interest, and fees for developers, which will allow projects to be completed faster and at lower costs. Finally, the federal government can incentivize cities that lower stringency by giving out federal grants and tax incentives. This will allow for more cities to build in places that are in need of more housing so that more townhouses, condos, and large family units can be constructed.

The next factor significantly associated with high home prices in this study is a city's population density ($p = 8.00 \times 10^{-5}$). One potential explanation for this relationship based on

prior research is that densely populated cities face constraints on space, meaning that demand is high despite limited space for housing supply. With high demand, housing prices rise, pricing low-income earners out of homeownership. In order to limit the effect of population density on housing prices, policymakers must address the drivers of high population density: land scarcity and high vertical construction costs. As a result, effective policies should focus on restoring land supply elasticity and promoting cost-effective construction.

First of all, governments should reform restrictive urban growth boundaries in order to allow cities to naturally expand into nearby land where property costs are cheaper. This will substantially increase the housing supply to match rising demand. Next, governments should focus on motivating cities to construct large buildings with less costly materials. As testified by California developer Nicholas Arenson, “buildings more than three stories tall require more steel, concrete, and elevators, making the construction cost per square foot much higher than single-family homes.” To combat this, policies should encourage cheaper wood-frame developments such as townhouses to avoid expensive costs associated with large steel skyscrapers (O’Toole).

The final factor contributing to high home prices is a city’s GDP ($p = 0.000114$). The reason behind this is that rising GDP attracts more investments and higher-waged labor, which expands the demand of buyers in that area with more purchasing power. As a result, the high-earning households are willing to pay more in the housing market, which drives up home prices. However, this leaves middle to low income workers priced out of the purchase market, forcing them to rent (“Link”). While rising GDP has a large effect on home prices, it may be difficult to change policies to combat GDP. This is because cities aim to have thriving economies and this is not something that should be fixed because it can affect the job growth in that city.

Limitations and Future Research

It is important to note that this study has several limitations that should be considered when analyzing the results and conducting further research. First, the analysis is limited to data from 2026 only, which is the year in which this paper was written. This limitation is due to the fact that it was difficult to obtain data from years prior for sixty different cities as websites continuously update their data to be more recent. In addition to this, analyzing a linear relationship across multiple cities and years requires too many dimensions to look at, which may skew the results of the study.

Next, the study examines sixty different U.S. cities, which may not fully represent the housing market across the entire United States. The cities are all relatively large and dense, which is somewhat inconsistent with metropolitan areas across all of the United States. Cities differ largely in their geography, economy, population growth, and housing supply and demand, and these differences substantially affect the more affordable decision to buy or rent. Future research should focus on more cities across the United States that are randomly selected to diversify contributing factors to homeownership.

Finally, it is most important to note that the analysis identifies a correlation between home prices and three different factors: regulatory stringency, population density, and Gross Domestic Product. However, this does not establish a causal relationship. Although the linear regression model shows convincing statistical evidence of a positive linear relationship between regulatory stringency, population density, GDP, and home prices, there may be other factors that contribute to this relationship. These variables may include interest rates, geography, and local economic policies that influence both regulatory stringency and home prices in the same way, for example. Therefore, a controlled experiment would need to be run to analyze causation, which is

nearly impossible with a large data set like this. To summarize, the statistical conclusion of the linear relationship should not be interpreted as evidence of causation and further research should be conducted.

Conclusion

Owning a home has historically been associated with wealth building, security, and milestones of adulthood. This is largely because real estate is viewed as an investment for the future and a place in which a family can live together.

However, home prices are continuing to rise substantially, exceeding middle-class budgets and forcing families to rent. As a result, families are unable to cover basic necessities and afford down payments for homes. This trend has been felt across different demographics and geographic areas, making this problem something to be aware of.

The factors that were discussed as major contributors to rising home prices are split into microeconomic and macroeconomic factors. Microeconomic factors include those that are directly inputted into the *New York Times* Rent vs. Buy Calculator. Macroeconomic factors include Stringency, Population Density, and Gross Domestic Product, which were tested and shown to be directly correlated with rising home prices.

As a result, it is important for policy makers to focus more on the macroeconomic factors that are often overlooked when considering the rise of home prices across US cities. The steps discussed include researching the impact of excessive regulations, making the regulatory process simpler, minimizing the cost of materials, and incentivizing cities that lower their stringency.

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